

Come dancing

Many birds perform courtship dances. Some are short and simple, but the great crested grebe's is amazingly complex. The two partners dance on the surface of a lake, and the complete performance involves several linked dances and displays. Each partner has to follow exactly the right steps. If all goes well, the pair forms a bond, and the female allows the male to mate.



Head-shaking dance

In the early stages of courtship, the partners swim up to each other, coming face to face. They wag their heads, pointing their bills up and down.



Dive and rush

Both birds dive to the bottom of the lake and grab a piece of weed. They bring it up to the surface and rush toward each other at high speed.



Weed ceremony

Paddling as hard as they can, the two birds rear up out of the water, presenting each other with the weed that they have collected.

Partners in slime

Great gray slugs are both male and female at the same time. But instead of fertilizing themselves, they need to find a partner, and then lower themselves from a long thread of slime. Next, the two slugs extend their reproductive organs, which look like umbrellas. They fertilize each other, and then crawl away to lay their eggs.

Broody pair

Swimming upside down, a male clownfish fertilizes his partner's bright orange eggs by squirting sperm onto them while they are glued to a rock. This way of breeding is called external fertilization, because it occurs outside the female's body. Once the eggs have been fertilized, the male clownfish takes charge of them until they hatch. He fans water over them with his fin and chases away egg-eating predators.



Entwined penises exchange sperm, so that each slug's eggs are fertilized

End of the affair

Some animal partnerships come to a quick and gruesome end. This female praying mantis has mated with a male and has started to eat him, beginning with his head. Despite losing his head, the male continues to fertilize the female, and his body provides her with a useful meal. Not all male mantises share this chilling fate—some manage to mate and then escape.

